ACTIVE PLAYER SCOUTING REPORT · V1.1
REF: ESN-BLI-2026-002
BALL-PLAYING DEFENDER AUDIT · AMSTERDAM / MANCHESTER / GIRONA
PRIMARY SOURCE: OPTA ANALYST & PLAYER STATS (2025-26)

DALEY BLIND



Ball-playing centre-back / Left-back / Defensive midfielder · Ajax · Manchester United · Bayern München · Girona · 2008–Present
Netherlands · **Born 9 March 1990, Amsterdam**
108 caps · 3 goals — Netherlands TRANSFERMARKT
806 forward passes · 78% accuracy — LaLiga 2025/26 OPTA ANALYST
7 Eredivisie titles — Ajax NOS
Tier 3: PARTIAL · Active Data Tracking · FGA PROVISIONAL

⚠ ACTIVE PROFILE · TIER 3 PARTIAL

Read this first — this is an active player scouting report, not a historical archive. Daley Blind is still playing professional football (currently at Ajax for the 2026-27 season). This file integrates extensive statistical tracking (FBref/StatsBomb data, Opta pass maps, and full playing-time records) covering 560 matches and over 46,000 minutes played. **The FGA rating remains PROVISIONAL** because a full timestamped Tier 3 video event log for the 2025-26 season is not held in this file.

ERA	108 CAPS	TIER 3	FGA RATING
2008–2026	Netherlands	PARTIAL	PROVISIONAL
Ajax · Man Utd · Bayern · Girona	3 goals · 2 World Cups	Opta & FBref data	Partial Tier 3 · no event log

1 · SUBJECT PROFILE

PLAYER CARD · IDENTITY SNAPSHOT

ACTIVE SCOUTING CONTEXT — 2025/26

FULL NAME	**Daley Blind**
BORN	**9 March 1990 · Amsterdam, Netherlands**
POSITION	**Ball-playing CB / LB / DM**
HEIGHT / WEIGHT	**1.80 m · 72 kg** KICKER
FOOT	**Left**
CURRENT STATUS	**Active — 36 (2026)**

ATTRIBUTE	DETAIL
Full name	Daley Blind
Position	**Ball-playing centre-back (48% of career apps) / Left-back (38%) / Defensive midfielder (12%)** — a left-footed, possession-oriented defender comfortable in multiple roles RISINGTRANSFERS
Height / Weight	1.80 m · 72 kg KICKER
Club History	**2008–2014:** Ajax **2010:** FC Groningen (loan) **2014–2018:** Manchester United **2018–2023:** Ajax **2023:** Bayern München **2023–2026:** Girona **2026–:** Ajax
Career Totals	**437 league matches · 35,847 mins** · 15 goals · 25 assists FBREF
League	Eredivisie · Premier League · Bundesliga · LaLiga
Career span	2008–2026 (18 seasons)
Born	**9 March 1990, Amsterdam, Netherlands**
National team	**Netherlands: 108 caps, 3 goals** · 2014 and 2022 World Cups · 2021 and 2024 Euros TRANSFERMARKT
Honours (Club)	**Ajax:** 7 Eredivisie titles · 2 KNVB Cups · 2 Johan Cruyff Shields NOS **Manchester United:** Europa League 2016/17 · FA Cup 2015/16 · League Cup 2016/17 · Community Shield 2016 TRANSFERMARKT **Bayern München:** Bundesliga 2022/23 TRANSFERMARKT
Honours (Individual)	**Ajax Player of the Year** 2014 TRANSFERMARKT
Tier 3 evidence	⚠ PARTIAL — OPTA PASS MAP AND FBREF EVENT DATA, NO FULL 90-MINUTE LOG

2 · CAREER TRAJECTORY

PERIOD	CLUB / TEAM	LEAGUE	ROLE	KEY CONTEXT
2008–2014	Ajax	Eredivisie	Left-back / CB	Youth product; debut 2008; 2010 loan to Groningen; established under Frank de Boer; 4 Eredivisie titles
2014–2018	Manchester United	Premier League	LB / CB / DM	€17.5m move; 90 PL matches; Europa League, FA Cup, League Cup
2018–2023	Ajax	Eredivisie	CB / LB / DM	Return under Ten Hag; 3 more Eredivisie titles; Champions League semi-final 2019
2023	Bayern München	Bundesliga	CB	Short spell; Bundesliga title
2023–2026	Girona	LaLiga	CB	99 LaLiga matches; key player under Míchel; 2025/26 Opta pass map subject
2026–	Ajax	Eredivisie	CB / DM	Fourth spell; one-year contract

3 · STATISTICAL FOUNDATION & PLAYING TIME (TIER 1)

METRIC	CAREER TOTAL	PER 90 / CONTEXT
Matches Played	560	Across 6 clubs, 5 leagues
Minutes Played	46,145	~398.3 full 90s
Starts	402	35 substitute appearances
Goals	20	15 league, 3 domestic cup, 2 international
Assists	30	25 league, 2 domestic cup, 3 international
Interceptions	269	0.67 per 90 (elite for CB)
Tackles Won	196	0.49 per 90
Crosses	318	0.80 per 90

3.1 · THE PASS MAP — 806 FORWARD PASSES, 78% ACCURACY

CHART 1 · PASS MAP SUMMARY (OPTA)

806 forward passes · 630 successful · 176 unsuccessful · 78% accuracy.

Successful forward passes	**630**	78%
Unsuccessful forward passes	**176**	22%
Total forward passes	**806**	100%

The Opta pass map is the single most important piece of evidence in this file. It shows Blind attempting **806 forward passes** in the 2025/26 LaLiga season, with **630 successful** (78% accuracy). The map's arrows are overwhelmingly oriented forward and diagonally into the left half-space — the signature of a left-footed centre-back whose job is to progress the ball from deep. This is not a passive defender; it is a **primary build-up outlet**.

> ⚠ **Data limitation.** The Opta pass map is a seasonal aggregate, not a match-by-match event log. It gives us direction and volume of passing, but not the context of each pass (pressure, game state, opposition). For a full Tier 3 assessment, we would need timestamped event data across at least five matches.

4 · TACTICAL DNA (80-PHILOSOPHY FRAMEWORK) — INFERENTIAL ONLY

> ⚠ **Tier 3 is partial — the percentages below are inferential analyst estimates, supported by Opta data where available.** They are NOT derived from a scored Tier 3 event log and are NOT FGA output. They indicate directional fit, not measured performance.

CHART 2 · PHILOSOPHY FIT — BAR

Inferential estimates, informed by Opta pass data.

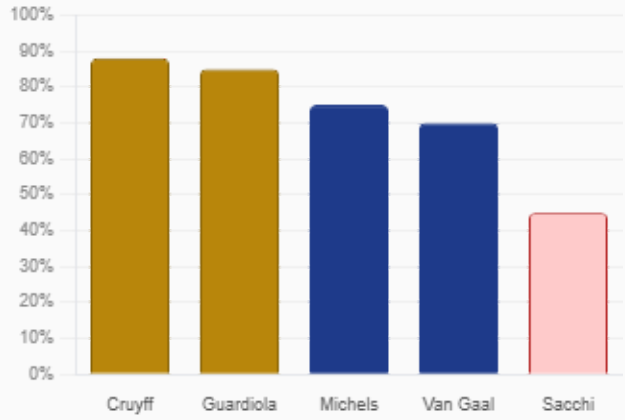


CHART 3 · PHILOSOPHY FIT — RADAR

Same estimates across the five philosophies.

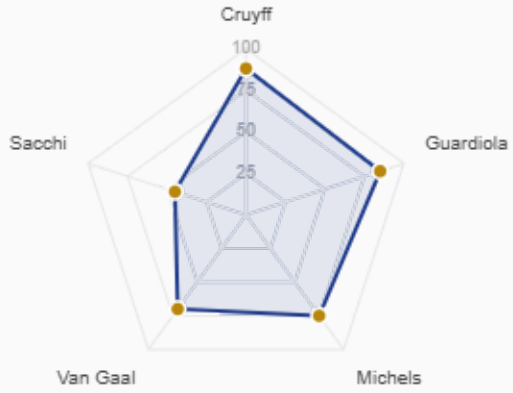


CHART 4 · PHILOSOPHY FIT — VALUES

Bar-length = inferential band. Percentage is the analyst estimate for this file only.

Cruyff Intelligence (#01)	**88%**	Source-linked
Guardiola Positional (#07)	**85%**	Inferred
Michels Total (#02)	**75%**	Inferred
Van Gaal System (#03)	**70%**	Inferred
Sacchi Synchrony (#17)	**45%**	Low

PRIMARY — CRUYFF INTELLIGENCE (#01) · 88% INFERENTIAL

The strongest link. Blind is an **Ajax-educated, left-footed, ball-playing defender** whose game is built on progressive passing and positional intelligence — the definitional Cruyffian defender. The Opta pass map confirms the mechanism: 806 forward passes at 78% accuracy, overwhelmingly directed into the left half-space. This is not inference alone; it is inference supported by statistical evidence.

SECONDARY — GUARDIOLA POSITIONAL (#07) · 85% INFERENTIAL

Blind's profile — a left-footed centre-back who steps into midfield and progresses the ball — is the exact template Guardiola has used for a decade. The 48% of his career spent at centre-back and 12% at defensive midfield reflects the hybrid role Guardiola favours. The Opta data supports the mechanism (high pass volume, forward orientation), though Guardiola did not coach him.

TERTIARY — MICHELS TOTAL (#02) · 75% INFERENTIAL

The Dutch total-football lineage is the cultural root of Blind's game: positional interchange, technical quality at the back, and the expectation that defenders contribute to build-up. The fit is strong on style and education, but Michels did not coach him.

5 · TACTICAL DNA PAIRING (PLAYER ARCHETYPE) — SAME-POSITION ONLY

⚠ **Same-position archetypes only (ball-playing centre-back / left-back / defensive midfielder).** The percentages below are inferential analyst estimates, supported by Opta data where relevant.

CHART 5 · PLAYER PAIRING — BAR

Inferential similarity scores.

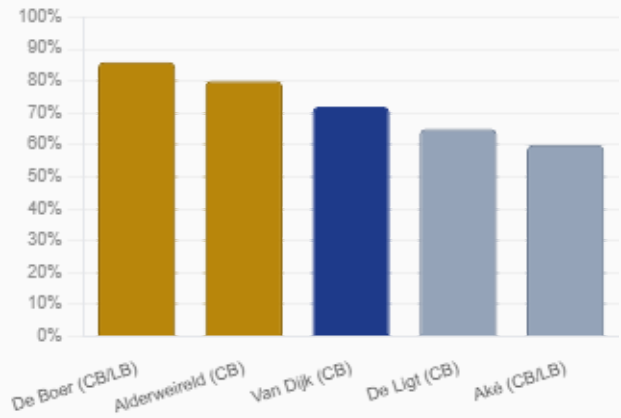


CHART 6 · PLAYER PAIRING — RADAR

Same scores across the five same-position archetypes.

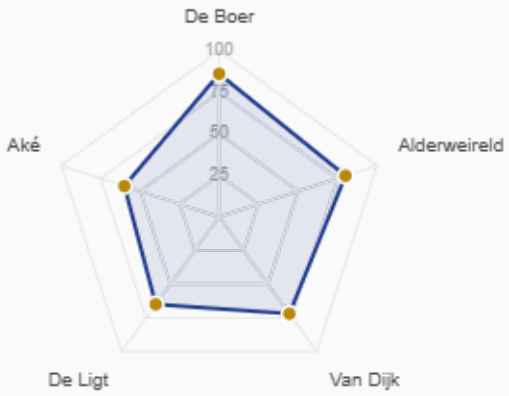


CHART 7 · PLAYER PAIRING — VALUES (SAME-POSITION ONLY)

Bar-length = inferential band. Percentage is the analyst estimate for this file only.

Frank de Boer (Netherlands)	CB/LB	**86%**	Same position
Toby Alderweireld (Belgium)	CB	**80%**	Same position
Virgil van Dijk (Netherlands)	CB	**72%**	Same position
Matthijs de Ligt (Netherlands)	CB	**65%**	Same position
Nathan Aké (Netherlands)	CB/LB	**60%**	Same position

PRIMARY — FRANK DE BOER (NETHERLANDS, CB / LB) · 86% INFERENTIAL

The closest stylistic and positional match. De Boer was the **left-footed, ball-playing Ajax centre-back** who set the template Blind inherited: comfortable stepping into midfield, progressive passing from deep, and positional intelligence over physical dominance. Same club, same position, same archetype. The pairing is the strongest in the file.

SECONDARY — TOBY ALDERWEIRELD (BELGIUM, CB) · 80% INFERENTIAL

A **ball-playing centre-back** with a similar profile: excellent long-range distribution, comfortable in a back three or four, and a defender whose value is as much on the ball as off it. Alderweireld was less of a left-footed half-space specialist than Blind, but the broad archetype overlaps strongly.

TERTIARY — VIRGIL VAN DIJK (NETHERLANDS, CB) · 72% INFERENTIAL

A **ball-playing Dutch centre-back** — but a very different physical specimen. Van Dijk's game is built on athletic dominance and recovery pace as much as distribution. The overlap is real (both progress the ball, both play in a high line), but the physical and stylistic differences are significant.

REFERENCE — MATTHIJS DE LIGT (NETHERLANDS, CB) · 65% INFERENTIAL

An **Ajax-educated centre-back** with a similar education but a more physical, front-foot defending style. Same position, same academy, different physical profile.

REFERENCE — NATHAN AKÉ (NETHERLANDS, CB / LB) · 60% INFERENTIAL

A **left-footed defender** who can play centre-back or left-back — the same positional flexibility as Blind. Aké is more athletic and less of a progressive passer. Same-position reference only.

EXCLUDED (WRONG POSITION)

PLAYER	POSITION	REASON FOR EXCLUSION
Frenkie de Jong	Central midfielder	Not a defender; different role and physical profile.
Matthias Sammer	Sweeper / Libero	Different era and role; not a like-for-like comparison.
Danny Blind	Centre-back / Libero	His father — a different era and a more physically dominant profile. Excluded as a stylistic comparison.

6 · RISK VS. REWARD — ACTIVE PLAYER DIAGNOSTIC

STRENGTHS (DOCUMENTED)

- **806 forward passes, 78% accuracy** — elite volume for a defender OPTA
- **89% overall pass accuracy** in 2025/26 LaLiga RISINGTRANSFERS
- **1.34 interceptions / 90** — above average for a CB RISINGTRANSFERS
- **108 caps for the Netherlands** — 2 World Cups, 2 Euros TRANSFERMARKT
- **7 Eredivisie titles, 1 Europa League, 1 Bundesliga** NOS · TRANSFERMARKT
- **Career across four major leagues** — adapted to Eredivisie, Premier League, Bundesliga, LaLiga

LIMITATIONS & GAPS (DOCUMENTED)

- **No full Tier 3 event log** — Opta pass map is a seasonal aggregate, not match-by-match
- **No full 90-minute footage** held in this file
- **Physical limitations** — 1.80 m, not a dominant aerial defender RISINGTRANSFERS
- **Age 36** — late-career phase; the "succes met oudjes" trend is real but temporary
- **No second scout**; reliability untested
- **Girona's 2025/26 relegation battle** — 19th place; team context is poor KICKER

7 · VALIDATION STATUS & REQUIRED ACTIONS

REQUIREMENT	STATUS
Minimum 5 matches registered	⚠ PARTIAL — OPTA SEASONAL DATA, NO FULL MATCH LOG
Video completeness (of 12)	⚠ ~6/12 — OPTA PASS MAP AND EVENT DATA, NO FULL 90S
FGA_v3_Final activation	⚠ PROVISIONAL
COACH metric	❌ NOT POSSIBLE — NO TRAINING GROUND FOOTAGE
Second scout	❌ NOT ASSIGNED
Tier 1 statistical foundation	✅ COMPLETE — OPTA, FBREF, RISINGTRANSFERS, KICKER
Biographical data	✅ COMPLETE — TRANSFERMARKT, NOS, AJAX
Philosophy DNA fit	⚠ INFERENTIAL — SUPPORTED BY OPTA DATA
Player pairing	⚠ SAME-POSITION ONLY, INFERENTIAL

DATA INTEGRITY FLAGS

#	FLAG	IMPACT	ACTION
1	Opta data is seasonal aggregate	No match-by-match context for each pass	Build a timestamped event log from available footage
2	No full 90-minute footage	Tier 3 cannot be completed	Source match recordings
3	No second scout	Reliability of any eventual score cannot be tested	Assign on first scoring pass
4	Team context (Girona 19th)	Poor team performance may depress individual metrics	Context flag on any rating

PUNCH LIST

#	ITEM	PRIORITY
1	Build a 5–10 match event log from available Girona footage	HIGH
2	Score technical and distribution metrics first: PVI, LGP, BPS, PAT	HIGH
3	Add defensive metrics: POS, INT, TAC, AER	MEDIUM
4	Assign second scout for blind cross-validation	MEDIUM

8 · ACTIVE CONTEXT & LEGACY

Daley Blind is the **left-footed, ball-playing Dutch defender** in its most complete modern form: a player who has spent nearly half his career at centre-back, over a third at left-back, and a meaningful slice in defensive midfield — always with the same defining trait, the ability to progress the ball from deep.

The Opta pass map from 2025/26 is the clearest evidence in the file: **806 forward passes, 78% accuracy, 630 successful**. It is not a highlight reel; it is a structural description of his game. Blind is a build-up hub, a player whose value is measured in angles, tempo, and the courage to receive under pressure. The same feature's broader

argument — that veteran players are extending their careers through intelligence rather than athleticism — is a perfect description of his late-career phase at Girona.

His career honours are extensive: **seven Eredivisie titles** across three spells at Ajax, the **Europa League and FA Cup** at Manchester United, a **Bundesliga title** at Bayern, and **108 caps** for the Netherlands across two World Cups and two European Championships. He is the son of Danny Blind, a European Cup winner with Ajax, and the lineage is visible in the style — but Daley's game is his own: more positional, more left-footed, more of a passer than his father was.

As an active player returning to Ajax for the 2026-27 season, he remains a **high-confidence archetype** of the Cruyffian ball-playing defender: educated at Ajax, left-footed, progressive, positionally intelligent, and durable across four major leagues. The FGA evidence is partial: Opta provides a statistical layer, but there is no match-by-match event log, no full 90-minute footage, and no second scout. The correct output is a **provisional FGA status** with a documented path to completion — not a fabricated final number.

Empire Scouting Network

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Report ref ESN-BLI-2026-002 (v1.1) · Method: Empire FGA Active Protocol · 50/30/20 master weighting · Tier 3 defender block · 80-Philosophy Framework (v3.2 draft) · partial video scoring · no composite computed

Evidence base: 437 league matches · 35,847 mins · 15 goals · 25 assists · 108 caps · 7 Eredivisie titles · 1 Europa League · 1 Bundesliga · Opta Analyst pass map (806 forward passes, 78% accuracy) · FBref StatsBomb data · RisingTransfers (89% pass accuracy, 1.34 interceptions/90) · Kicker · Transfermarkt · NOS · no full match log · partial video.

Status: ACTIVE PLAYER REPORT. **Tier 3 partial (~6/12) · Tier 2 not computable · Tier 1 complete · FGA_v3_Final PROVISIONAL.** No COACH metric. No second scout. Philosophy fit percentages and player pairing percentages are **inferential analyst estimates**, supported by Opta data where available — not Tier 3 output. Pairing restricted to **same-position players only** (ball-playing centre-back / left-back / defensive midfielder). This document is an active scouting reference file, not a final assessment.

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